



Europe

United Kingdom

The flag of the UK is known as the "Union Jack."

Basalt columns are said to look like stepping stones for giants.

Giant's Causeway

These spectacular hexagonal basalt columns on the coast of Northern Ireland were formed from volcanic lava 50 million years ago.



0 100 km
0 100 miles
(approximate scale)



Medieval strongholds

The UK has many castles—the fortresses of ancient monarchs and nobles. The well-preserved 13th-century Harlech Castle (left) is one of many in Wales.



Cream tea

An afternoon tea of scones, homemade jam, clotted cream, and a cup of hot tea is a national treat.

Caribbean carnival

London is a multicultural city, and its annual Notting Hill Carnival is a celebration of Caribbean culture. Millions flock to enjoy the live music, dancing, and colorful parades.



Channel Islands

Guernsey, Jersey, and other islands in the English Channel are self-governing.



Celtic Sea

Isles of Scilly

Penzance

Plymouth

Falmouth

Torquay

Bournemouth



94,058 sq miles (243,610 sq km)

66 million

London

English, other languages (+3)

Off the **northwest coast of Europe** lies the United Kingdom, or UK, which consists of four small countries—**England, Scotland, Wales, and Northern Ireland**. This island nation is steeped in history. The UK is famous for its **royal family, theater, modern music, and red buses**.